

Our approach to design principles

Too often, design principles fall into the trap of **sounding good without actually being useful**.

When principles read like truisms

“AI should be trustworthy,” “prioritize the user,” “support human judgment”

they’re hard to disagree with, but even harder to design from. That’s why we took a different approach.

Instead of treating principles as declarations of truth, **we treated them as reasoned tradeoffs**. We wrote each principle so that its opposite is also plausible—something a smart, thoughtful team might believe, in a different context, or with different goals. This forces us to confront the nuance behind real design choices. It pushes us past default thinking and asks: What are we really optimizing for? And why?

What this approach looks like:

- Each principle takes a clear stance with a credible counterpoint.
- The principle and its opposite both hold water—but imply different values, priorities, or assumptions.
- The goal isn’t to win a debate, but to clarify the lens through which we’re designing.